DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

What Does God's Oneness Really Mean?

Daat Tevunot, Summary

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** Revision: the summaries of sections 1 and 2, and the start of the summary of section 3 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Tuesday 10 January 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Back from the break

This was the first class after the winter break. The Rabbi welcomed everyone back, thanked Morris for bringing more copies of the book, and noted that the group was growing. Before the break he had asked everyone to revise the summaries of the first three sections. This class went through them together, using the summaries at the end of each section in the English edition, "because we have to go over the fundamentals as we get back into it".

Section 1: why God created the world

The book is a dialogue between the Neshamah and the Sekhel, the soul and the intellect. The Neshamah has questions about the basic principles of faith: divine providence, reward and punishment of the righteous and the wicked, the meaning of mashiah, and the events of history that seem unjust. The Sekhel answers that before any of this can be addressed we must understand why we are in the world at all.

The Rabbi called this "such an important paragraph": God is the ultimate good and wants to give the greatest possible good. The ultimate good is God Himself, and God cannot create another God, so the greatest good is to let creatures connect to Him, to cleave to Him. For that, man is created imperfect, with the task of perfecting himself, so that he earns his reward and is not ashamed to receive it. The Rabbi added a point from earlier classes: what you earn becomes part of you; what is simply given remains external.

To allow perfection and imperfection, good and bad, God had to withdraw Himself to some extent.

Was Adam created perfect? A participant asked this, and the Rabbi answered no. A person who is perfect cannot sin; those who reach olam haba will have no ability to sin. The pull towards sin has to come from something lacking inside a person. "The very fact itself that Adam sins means that there was something within him which wasn't perfect."

Section 2: the revelation of God's oneness

The revelation of the Yihud Hashem, God's oneness, is the central element of all creation, and the Ramhal returns to it throughout the book.

What oneness means. Not just "one and not two". It means there is no force, power or authority in the universe other than God. The Rabbi recalled the five mistaken views discussed earlier: that God created the world and abandoned it; that there are two powers; that the world is run by nature; that God has abandoned us; and that a creature can successfully rebel against Him. Yihud Hashem denies all of them. He returned to his analogy of the world you imagine with your eyes closed, which exists only while you will it.

He admitted this is very hard to live by. If people truly lived with it, life would be tranquil and mashiah would have come long ago. He linked it to mesirut nefesh when saying Shema, as the group had learned in Derech Hashem: a person who is willing to give up himself sees himself as having no existence apart from God, while "any element of ego is a denial of Yihud Hashem". That is why Shema is in our mezuzot and tefillin, and why it is said when a baby is born and when a person dies.

Only a negative can be revealed. Each of God's attributes is infinite, and a finite mind cannot grasp the infinite. What God can reveal is a negative: that there is nothing apart from Him. The world appears full of competing powers, good and bad, people doing as they please. The revelation of His oneness will be the recognition that all of it comes under His banner. That is the theme of Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, when we pray that all wickedness will vanish and all will form one band.

Evil must exist and then be destroyed. For this negative to be revealed there has to be a facade to remove, and that is why there is evil, both the tragedies of the world and human wrongdoing. At the end of days all of it will dissipate and be seen as part of God's plan.

Two ways it can come. Through us: every time a person resists a sin he affirms that God is in control, and every sin denies it. Or by itself: at the end of six thousand years, through what is always working behind the scenes.

The conclusion. If the world ran only on reward and punishment, good and evil would coexist forever. Since God has promised that evil will be destroyed and the world redeemed, the revelation of His oneness must be the fundamental principle. Once it is revealed there will be no more free choice.

Section 3: the time of concealment

The Rabbi began reading the summary of section 3 inside, since the group had not done this before. It describes the phase of hester panim, when God's oneness is concealed. Whatever we say about God (compassionate, mighty) describes how He wishes to be perceived, not His essence.

God conceals His power so that man can choose. If God were revealed, a person about to sin would simply be unable to. A participant mentioned the Gemara's account of Yosef seeing his father's image and freezing. The Rabbi distinguished: that was Yosef choosing to reveal God's oneness to himself; if God revealed Himself, there would be no choice at all.

The concealment is never total, or nothing would exist. It is temporary, no more than six thousand years. Meanwhile there are two modes: hanhagat hamishpat, where God judges according to the system and "His hands are tied, as it were", and the hidden mode of His sovereignty and goodness, which perfects the world even when it is undeserved.

Living with it: lashon hara and Yosef

Asked how one lives with this, the Rabbi gave lashon hara as an example. We know it is wrong yet speak it constantly, because we think we will gain from it. "If you believe in Yihud Hashem… I'm not going to gain from it. Hashem is in control." We still have temptations, but they lose their hold.

Asked whether God's protection of the Jewish people through history is not already a revelation, he said a believer who sees God in these events has revealed it for himself, but it is not yet revealed to the world. If it were, there would be no wars and no fighting, and this applies to all humanity.

His main example was Yosef, whose generous response to his brothers came from living with Yihud Hashem. Sold, falsely accused and imprisoned, he recognised that it was all part of a plan that made him able to sustain his family and the world. The group also discussed the Hazal that he stayed two more years in prison for asking the butler to mention him to Pharaoh.

Summary

- Section 1: God created the world to give the ultimate good, connection to Him, which man must earn; so He created man imperfect, and even Adam was not perfect.
- Section 2: Yihud Hashem means there is no power at all besides God; only this "negative" can be revealed, which requires evil to exist and then be destroyed.
- Section 3: in the time of concealment God conceals His power to allow choice, judges by the mode of justice, and works in hidden ways towards the final perfection.
- Living with Yihud Hashem removes the pull of sins like lashon hara, as Yosef's response to his brothers shows.

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